



Google Photos tags

You can finally tag people in your pictures in Google Photos. If Google detects a face that is. <https://digit.in/dec19-24>



Alexa gets emotions

Amazon's voice-activated digital assistant Alexa is learning to read text with different emotions. <https://digit.in/dec19-25>

you expect it the least. This is the most ethically-sound dark pattern though, and things just get crazier from here. Let's look at some of the most commonly utilised dark patterns.

MOST COMMONLY-USED DARK PATTERNS

Dark patterns work. They lead to profit, there's no doubt about it, which is why they are so ubiquitous. They are a quick means to the end for businesses, since long-term, qualitative growth stemmed for user satisfaction and happiness can be quite a tedious and, in some cases, expensive affair. These are some of the common dark patterns out there that you, as a content consumer, should be wary of.

Confirmshaming

This is where the UX design exploits the users by making them feel guilty or simply feel FOMO. Statements such as "I'm not interested in discount deals" or "I don't care about my child's health" are a few abhorrent examples. Check out this Tumblr page for more – <https://digit.in/CS>.

Disguised ads

These sneaky tactics disguise ads as part of the clickable content – buttons, sliders, registration. The primary goal of such dark patterns is to confuse the user into clicking them and *cha-ching*. You may have seen this on pages where you can download free software. The UX designers make the 'clickable ads' large and sometimes, green, to indicate this is the right way to go, when in fact, the actual download button is a tiny speck concealed in a pool of treachery.

Forced continuity

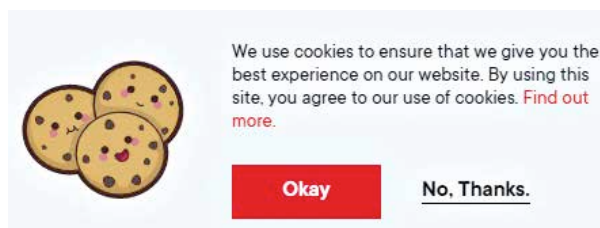
Most services today tend to lure customers by offering them a free trial for a limited period of time. However, your card details are mandatory to avail this free trial. Soon, months go by and you find that your statements indicate a monthly fee has been deducted after your trial period ended without any indicators or warnings. Audible is one such example where users are given a

month's worth of free trial after which the company sends no emails or notifications reminding users that they will be charged henceforth.

Persuasive formatting

Colours and design theories are often used to condition and ultimately, mislead consumers in UX. In the image shown, the 'Okay' (which agrees to use of cookies) is highlighted and looks like the obvious choice whereas the 'No, Thanks' looks plain and doesn't have a highlighting background. This tricks users into believing that clicking 'Okay' is the correct option and clicking the 'No, Thanks' may lead to undesirable consequences.

Other methods such as Roach Model, Trick Questions, Sneak Item into Basket, Privacy Zuckering (named after Mark Zuckerberg), Hidden Costs, Bait and



Switch and Friend Spam are also prevalent dark patterns. You can read more about them on darkpatterns.org.

WHY COMPANIES SHOULD STRAY AWAY FROM DARK PATTERNS

The idea of dark patterns in UX does indeed seem irresistible since it does shoot up profits and benefits, temporarily at least. Eventually, this unethical practice may very well have tons of negative implications. One of the most telling examples of the negative consequences arisen from dark patterns is LinkedIn's friend spam fiasco. The company was actually sued for \$13 million over its use of dark patterns in an onboarding process. LinkedIn tricked users into importing their entire address book and sent spam friend emails to their contacts.

The consumer or customer has also become more aware. Gone are the days of customers being naive, now they know about user manipulating tricks and will eventually walk away from a

service that employs these too aggressively. According to a study by Impact, 79 per cent users stray to another website if they are displeased with the content of a particular website.

Microsoft is yet another company which came under the spotlight for using deceptive design. Microsoft prompted users to upgrade to Windows 10 when the new version came out. However, the X button on the prompt to upgrade did not cancel or postpone the upgrade process. Instead, clicking the cross (x) actually initialised the upgrade right then and there. This brought on massive backlash from the online community.

Yet another tech giant, Facebook, was also called out for misleading wordings when it came to disabling the facial recognition feature. It warns

users not to opt out of the service since disabling this feature can lead to other users impersonating you or using your photograph in the wrong context. This is a

form of emotional manipulation which uses carefully structured sentences to usher the user to do something that benefits the company ultimately.

Since the proliferation of the term dark patterns, researches and studies have been conducted to study them and their unethical usage. The increasing trend of dark patterns is causing new design laws to emerge that attempt to nip the issue at the bud. Recently, Congressional leaders in the US have taken up arms against the practice and are in talks of banning it altogether.

Ultimately, tricking users into converting to paid subscribers, clicking on ads, and accepting cookies or notifications fractures the image of the business. Short term gains may seem elusive, but the long-term damages impact businesses the most. Fortunately, awareness about 'dark patterns' and their usage is more commonplace now and regulatory action seems to be on the horizon. 